



METHODOLOGY



BRIGHTER FUTURES:

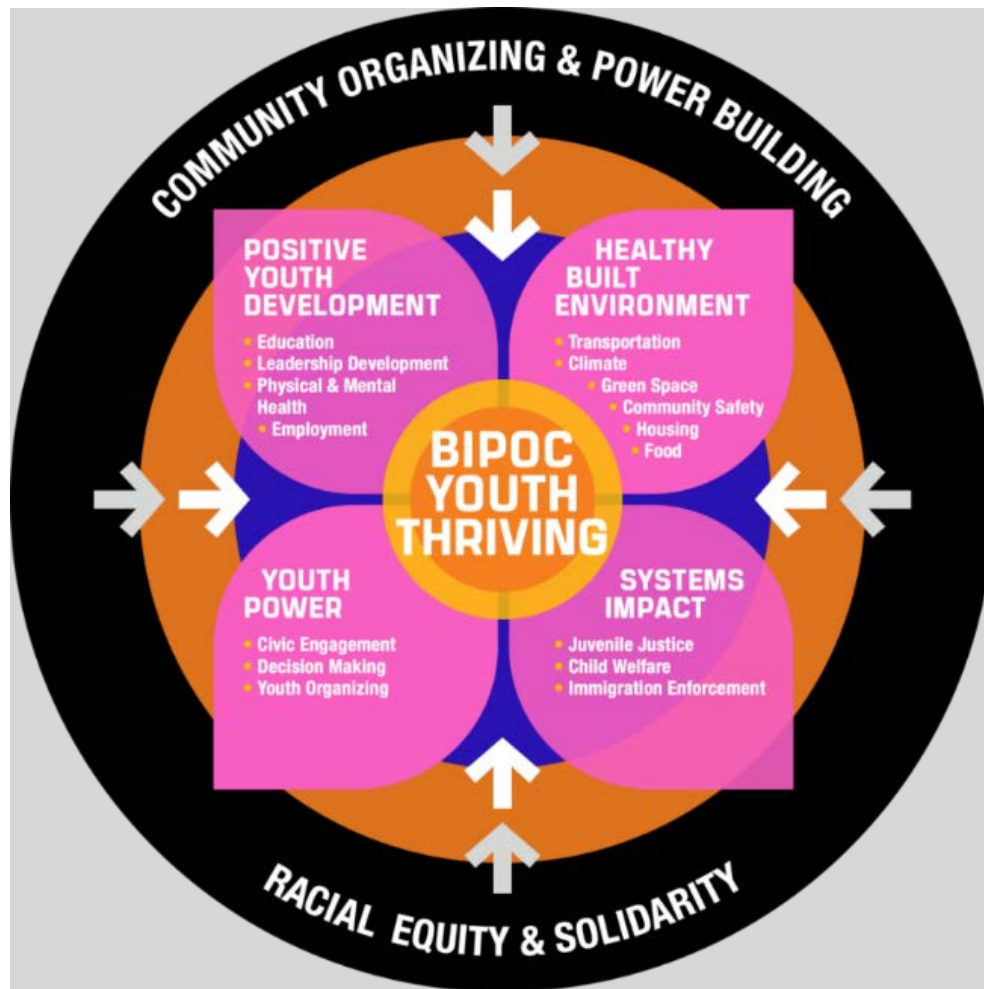
The Bold Vision Youth Thriving Survey

SEPTEMBER 2025

Bold Vision is a multi-sector, multi-generational initiative that aims to transform Los Angeles County into a community where Black, Indigenous, People of Color (BIPOC) youth thrive. Beginning in 2019, Bold Vision embarked on an extensive community engagement process to define the supports, resources, and conditions youth need to reach their fullest potential. This included identifying a set of indicators that could track progress toward creating these conditions. The [Bold Vision Mid-term Report](#) explores many of these indicators in depth, but Catalyst California identified a large gap in existing data – firsthand accounts from youth on how they are thriving. The Bold Vision Youth Thriving Survey (BVYTS) aimed to fill that gap. To date, the BVYTS is the largest survey on youth well-being in L.A. County that directly engages youth. It is the key measurement of progress toward Bold Vision’s goal for BIPOC youth to thrive.

This methodology provides an overview of our methods for developing the BVYTS and analyzing its results, as shown in the *Brighter Futures: The Bold Vision Youth Thriving Survey* report. For a copy of the report, please visit: www.boldvisionla.org/reports/. For information on other indicators in the Bold Vision youth development framework, please review the [Bold Vision Mid-term Report](#). For access to our scripts and visuals, visit our [GitHub repository](#).

Bold Vision Youth Development Framework



Acknowledgements

We thank and acknowledge everyone who played a role in developing and implementing the BVYTS. This includes, but is not limited to, the former Bold Vision Community Council, Bold Vision Youth Council, Bold Vision Steering Committee, Social Justice Learning Institute staff, Catalyst California staff, and members of Bold Vision's Survey Advisory Group. Feedback from these stakeholders was imperative to Catalyst California designing and analyzing the BVYTS.

This work would not have been possible without deep collaboration from our research partners and the community-based organizations that collected surveys. We would like to thank Imoyase Community Support Services and the Community Health Equity Group for their contributions to designing and implementing the Bold Vision Youth Thriving Survey. Cheryl Grills, Ph.D., Sandra Villanueva, Ph.D., Elia De La Cruz Toledo He, Ph.D., Peter Rej, Ph.D., Diane Terry, Ph.D., and other staff at Imoyase Community Support Services conducted the literature review for the survey and

led the design of the survey questionnaire and sampling plan. Jason Douglas, Ph.D. (University of California Irvine), Andy Subica, Ph.D. (UC Riverside), Aerika Loyd, Ph.D. (UC Riverside), and UC Irvine (UCI) graduate researchers led the data collection and received Institutional Review Board approval for the survey implementation from UCI. We would also like to thank the 41 youth-serving organizations who distributed the Bvyts and helped this survey represent a broad cross-section of L.A. County youth.

Lastly, we would like to thank the Bold Vision Survey Advisory Group members who have helped shape the survey and report since 2022. This includes: Dr. David Turner, Assistant Professor of Black Life & Racial Justice, University of California Los Angeles; Dr. Fiorella Carlos Chavez, Assistant Professor in Community Health, Arizona State University; Royce Park, Assistant Director of Survey Planning and Operations for the California Health Interview Survey, University of California Los Angeles; Sahar Moheize, Research, Policy, & Innovation Director, L.A. County Department of Youth Development; Dr. Veronica Terriquez, Associate Professor of Sociology, University of California Los Angeles; and Dr. Yan Cui, Supervising Epidemiologist, L.A. County Department of Public Health.

Youth Thriving Survey Overview

The Bvyts instrument and sampling strategy are informed by existing youth thriving measures, youth interviews, prior research, and input from two Bold Vision collectives. These include the former Community Council – a collective of 13 youth-serving organizations from throughout the county – and the Survey Advisory Group (SAG), a collective of survey and research experts co-facilitated by Imoyase Community Support Services (ICSS) and Catalyst California.¹ Over 40 youth-focused surveys and research articles were reviewed to develop the sampling strategy, and nearly two dozen literature sources were analyzed to define “youth thriving”. Additionally, six group interviews with 70 youth participants were conducted across the county to ensure the Bvyts defined and measured youth thriving according to the cultural context of BIPOC youth.

In partnership with Community Health Equity Group (CHE Group) at University of California, Irvine and University of California, Riverside, Bold Vision collected over 3,000 survey responses between October 2023 and June 2024. Bold Vision worked with over 40 youth-serving community-based organizations to gather a sample representative of L.A. County youth. This study was approved by the University of California Irvine Institutional Review Board.

¹ The Community Council has since been reconfigured as the Steering Committee, a group of youth-serving organizations and youth leaders from throughout the county.

SURVEY VALUES

Bold Vision established survey values to ground the need for an evidence-based tool with the voice of today's youth and their diverse cultures. These values guided the survey design, collection, and analysis:

1. **Culturally grounded** | The survey is grounded in understanding BIPOC youth cultures and environment.
2. **Credibility** | The survey balances the limitations of research best practices with cultural context and community engagement.
3. **Youth-defined** | The survey is informed by youth voices and engagement. It prioritizes youth-thriving domains and methods that resonate with BIPOC youth.
4. **Innovative** | The survey is courageous in expanding the definition of robust research and survey methods.
5. **Replicable** | The survey is resource-effective and replicable in the future.
6. **Transparent and accessible** | The survey's methods, development, and findings are transparent and accessible to BIPOC youth and communities.
7. **Communication and engagement power** | The survey engages BIPOC youth and provokes action from systems because of its robustness.
8. **Asset-based and challenge-based** | The survey highlights the assets of BIPOC youth and calls out core challenges that prevent youth from thriving.
9. **Racial equity and justice** | The survey design and methods recognize the role of structural racism in the experiences and development of BIPOC youth.
10. **Systems change** | The survey provides actionable information to transform how systems operate and serve young people in the county.

SURVEY INSTRUMENT

The Bvyts asked 62 questions over seven different components of youth thriving. Catalyst California and ICSS modified items from existing validated instruments or created new ones where there were no existing measures. We prioritized items not measured in existing data sources. The survey components were largely derived from the Ettinger THRIVE framework and modified based on Bold Vision's engagement with youth, community partners, and the SAG.²

The survey also included 15 demographic questions to measure differences in youth thriving across youth subgroups. Some of these included race, immigration status, sexual orientation,

² Anna K. Ettinger et al., "A Community Partnered Approach for Defining Child and Youth Thriving," *Academic Pediatrics* 21, no. 1 (2021): 53–62, <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.acap.2020.04.011>.

gender identity, age, housing status, criminal legal system involvement, employment, and education status.

BOLD VISION YOUTH THRIVING COMPONENTS

We originally defined 10 components of youth thriving based on our literature review, input from the SAG, and feedback from youth. They were intended to complement the existing Bold Vision framework and provide a detailed definition of Bold Vision's key goal – BIPOC youth thriving. The first eight components are from the Ettinger THRIVE framework. We added two more components to encompass a more holistic picture of youth thriving. These 10 components represent Bold Vision's full definition of what it means for youth to thrive. However, not all of these were included as measures in the survey or as findings in the *Brighter Futures* report.

1. **Strong Minds and Bodies** | Youth having positive mental and physical health, which includes but is not limited to positive emotions, health behaviors, and cognitive development. Also referred to as Strong Mental Health and Minds and encompassing the subcomponent psychological distress.
2. **Positive Identity and Hope** | Youth having a strong sense of self, purpose, self-worth, and hope for the future. Encompassing the subcomponent self-efficacy and hope for the future, as well as spark.
3. **Caring Families and Relationships** | The relational aspects of youth thriving, including friendships, caregiver relationships, and school relationships that provide caring, stable, and positive support.
4. **Racial Equity, Opportunity, and Inclusion** | Youth feeling comfortable, accepted, and included in all spaces they enter, regardless of race/ethnicity, gender, sexuality, religion, health status, and appearance, including whether youth interactions with public systems are fair and equitable. Encompassing the subcomponents of microaggressions, structural racism, and experiences of racism and discrimination.
4. **Vibrant Communities** | The local resources available to youth, such as open public spaces, safe spaces, and accessible public transportation.
5. **Safety** | Youth feeling safe in their neighborhoods, at school, and in their communities, such as physically safe spaces, secure relationships (not fearing bullying or violence), and protected development (free to be children).
6. **Fun and Happiness** | Opportunities for youth to experience enjoyment and happiness.
7. **Healthy Environments** | Healthy, accessible physical and social environments, such as clean air and water, quality medical services, mental health resources, social services, and healthy food.

9. **Cultural and Ethnic Identity** | Youth connecting to their cultural or ethnic identity, which includes healing practices, ethnic pride, and family traditions.

10. **Spirituality** | Youth having transcendental awareness or spiritual connection, including the pursuit of higher meaning and purpose in life.

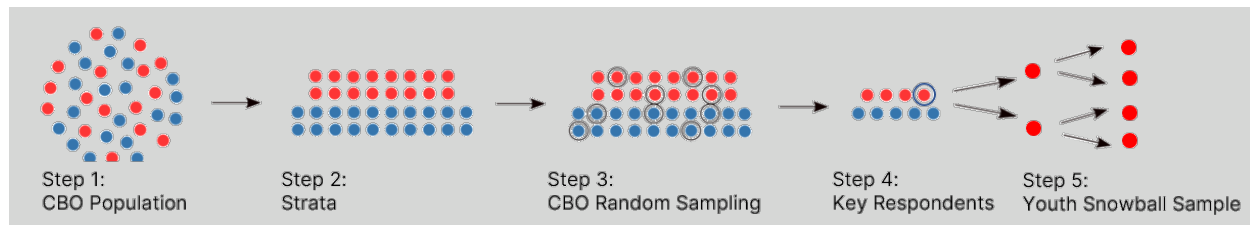
We developed the BGYTS based on these 10 components but prioritized specific items to shorten the length of the survey. In the final survey, questions for seven components were included based on SAG feedback, youth interviews, ICSS' expertise, Bold Vision's priorities, and data gaps in Bold Vision's prior reports. These components were further refined and split as needed based on our factor analysis, discussed in detail below.

HYBRID SAMPLING APPROACH

We considered a variety of sampling methods from random sampling, where researchers randomly select participants, to convenience sampling, where researchers survey participants who are easiest for them to access. There are benefits and drawbacks to each method. Random sampling methods are typically used to reduce selection bias but are often ineffective in gathering sufficient sample sizes for hard-to-reach populations. Conversely, convenience sampling methods can help access hard-to-reach populations but may increase selection bias. In our review, we found that most youth surveys used a convenience-based method like snowball sampling, where youth refer their friends to the survey, and/or a randomized method like stratified sampling, where youth are split into different groups and then randomly selected within each group. Ultimately, we decided on a hybrid approach that combines both random and convenience sampling methods to reduce selection bias and increase the likelihood of gathering enough responses from hard-to-reach youth.

Specifically, Bold Vision used stratified sampling to randomly select community-based organizations (CBOs) and then used snowball sampling to distribute the survey among youth members of the selected CBOs. These young people then invited their friends to complete the survey. Bold Vision originally selected 35 CBOs from a total of 313 L.A. County-based youth-serving organizations, of which 24 agreed to participate. CBOs were split into different strata, or subgroups, based on their geographic region or target population served (e.g., Asian American/Native Hawaiian or Pacific Islander, American Indian/Alaska Native, Black boys/men, transgender/nonbinary, LGBTQ+, unhoused, foster, or justice-involved youth). The number of CBOs randomly selected from each subgroup was determined by the proportion of L.A. County youth in each subgroup and the capacity of the CBOs. If a CBO declined to participate, another organization was selected from the same strata. Throughout survey distribution, respondent demographics were monitored to flag if additional CBOs were needed to reach the target number of respondents in each youth demographic. By the end of the survey period, Bold Vision partnered with 41 CBOs to reach youth in L.A. County. In addition to the CBO sampling approach, Bold Vision Youth Council members distributed the survey at Bold Vision community events to supplement the sample. Surveys were done online and shared with youth via web links and QR codes.

Hybrid Sampling Approach Conceptual Diagram (Modified from Baeldung)³



INCENTIVES

Catalyst California and the CHE Group provided CBOs with technical assistance in distributing the survey. They were given scaled stipends of either \$2,500 or \$10,000, depending on the number of responses they collected, and received a \$2,000 bonus payment if they collected 175 or more responses. Young people who completed the survey were emailed a \$10 gift card of their choosing after completing the survey. Those who invited their peers to participate were provided raffle tickets for additional incentives through participating CBOs.

CONSENT

Youth ages 18 and over provided electronic consent before participating in the survey, whereas a two-step passive parent/guardian consent process was initially used for youth ages 17 and younger. Prospective participants ages 17 and younger were electronically routed to a youth assent form. After agreeing to participate, the youth were prompted to enter their email address and a parent/guardian's email address. A study information sheet was then emailed to their parent/guardian. Parents/guardians had seven days to opt-out their youth from the survey. If they did not opt-out, the survey link was emailed to the youth. This passive consent process was modified during data collection as most youth under 18 failed to return to the survey after the 7-day waiting period passed. Later in data collection, once youth completed their assent forms, they were immediately emailed a link to the survey. Parents/guardians had seven days to “opt-out” of the survey, where if they chose to, their youths’ information would be deleted from the survey data.

SURVEY LIMITATIONS AND FUTURE RESEARCH

The Bvyts touched on nearly every factor of youth thriving. The sample size was the largest of youth surveys in L.A. County that we know of. However, there are several opportunities to build on the Bvyts foundation and address limitations in the survey data and design. The limitations discussed below should be considered when designing future research and interpreting trends.

³ Baeldung, “Stratified Sampling in Machine Learning | Baeldung on Computer Science,” Baeldung, <https://www.baeldung.com/cs/ml-stratified-sampling>.

First, to limit survey length and fatigue, we prioritized items unavailable in existing surveys and limited the number of questions. For instance, we did not include questions about different types of relationships—such as peers, families, community relationships, and mentors—that support youth. Rather, the BGYTS focused generally on whether youth had someone they could turn to in good and bad times, which had a significant effect on youth thriving. Future research could learn more about how different types of relationships contribute to youth thriving.

Additionally, the survey included relatively few measures on growth mindset, community involvement, and personal safety. While we did not find a significant relationship between our growth mindset measures and outcomes, prior research has demonstrated a positive effect of growth mindset on youth thriving indicators.⁴ Future studies could include other measures of growth mindset. Similarly, we found evidence of the importance of community involvement and personal safety for thriving youth. The effect sizes were lower for these two areas, but they each included only a single question. Future studies could explore how young people's feelings of safety in different settings, e.g., during the day or night, at school, and in the workplace, affect thriving. Similarly, future studies could explore other measures of community involvement beyond whether youth feel they have opportunities to get involved, e.g., the types of community engagement they are involved in – volunteer work, extracurricular activities, and political or civic engagement.

The survey did not include items on physical health and spirituality/religion that prior research supports as important to youth thriving. Physical health can affect a youth's psychological well-being and be a symptom of psychological distress for youth. Some youth may also be more likely to manifest psychological distress as somatic symptoms in the body. Future studies could include physical health measures as predictors of youth thriving and measures of youth mental health. Lastly, the BGYTS only included one question about access to religious facilities and one question about connection to spiritual/religious traditions. Future studies could include more comprehensive measures of spirituality/religiosity.

The BGYTS included extensive demographic measures to explore differences in youth thriving for various subgroups. However, it did not include youth disability status, which can affect youth outcomes and moderate the effect of other factors. In our sessions with youth, we also heard about the compounding effect of having systems-impacted or undocumented family members, as well as experiencing poverty, on youth stress. The BGYTS asked questions about young people's history with the criminal legal system and their immigration status, but it did not ask similar questions about their family members. Youth poverty is regarded as an important factor in youth thriving, but we only studied the effect of poverty tangentially by controlling for neighborhood poverty levels in our structural equation modeling. We found that neighborhood poverty did not

⁴ Weidong Tao et al., "The Influence of Growth Mindset on the Mental Health and Life Events of College Students," *Frontiers in Psychology* 13 (April 2022), <https://doi.org/10.3389/fpsyg.2022.821206>.

have a significant effect on youth thriving outcomes when accounting for other factors, but future research could include socioeconomic questions to confirm these results.

The BGYTS sampling design also included important limitations. The survey was limited to ages 15-24 to help ensure questions were understandable to youth, and was cross-sectional in design, meaning data was collected at a single point-in-time. Surveying younger groups, combined with longitudinal studies, could help point to factors early in childhood that affect outcomes in adolescence or young adulthood. The BGYTS sampling design was unique in stratifying sampling by CBOs' target constituents. This included partnering with specific organizations working with hard-to-reach AIAN and NHPI youth. However, our survey sample still had low counts for these groups, which might limit the generalizability of the results. Future studies could try additional methods to oversample these populations. The sampling design also initially targeted youth connected to community-based organizations. Prior research points to the validity of using community outreach referrals to reach more participants.⁵ However, methods could be improved by clearly identifying in the survey the young people who were connected to existing CBOs versus those reached through snowball sampling. This would allow for comparisons between these two groups to test for similarities and differences.

Future studies may also include open-ended questions to help contextualize trends further. After survey collection, we conducted two listening sessions with Youth Council members. These sessions provided rich content that helped make sense of trends and raise questions for future research. Open-ended questions could expand the scope of qualitative findings and lead to additional insights.

Bold Vision research partners can continue expanding the rich results of the BGYTS either by collecting additional data or analyzing existing BGYTS data. Our analysis included factor analysis and structural equation modeling to identify starting points for policy change in L.A. County. Our modeling was mostly done for youth as a whole, but our initial findings show some important differences for youth subgroups. Models for cisgender and Black youth suggest components may vary in their effects by youth subgroup. While overall we found similar components had significant effects across models, the relative magnitude of the effects varied by group. As such, future studies using the BGYTS could explore multilevel modeling or other statistical models to identify whether focusing on certain components for policy interventions may yield greater benefits for specific youth subgroups.

⁵ Monica P. Bhatt et al., "Predicting and Preventing Gun Violence: An Experimental Evaluation of READI Chicago," *The Quarterly Journal of Economics* 139, no. 1 (2024): 1–56, <https://doi.org/10.1093/qje/qjad031>.

Overview of Report Methods

Our analysis methods broadly aimed to answer: (1) what are the primary drivers of youth thriving and (2) how youth are faring across these drivers. The purpose was to identify starting points for policy change. Input from the Bold Vision Youth Council, former Community Council members, Steering Committee, and SAG informed these questions. Based on their input, we focused on two main outcomes gathered in the survey that are often associated with youth thriving: psychological distress and self-efficacy/hope for the future. During feedback sessions, Youth Council members described how other areas of their lives impact their mental well-being, self-confidence, and hope. Therefore, our research questions and methods sought to identify the BGYTS components and youth characteristics that had a statistically significant, measurable effect on these two outcomes.

Our methods involved these steps, each discussed in detail below:

- (1) We screened survey responses to ensure respondents met our eligibility criteria and did not include invalid surveys.
- (2) We weighted survey responses based on population benchmarks for youth ages 15-24 in L.A. County to adjust survey results for biased sampling by sex, age, race, or region.
- (3) We conducted a series of descriptive analyses by respondent demographics for all items included in the survey, weighing results by our survey weights. This allowed us to compare responses across key demographics.
- (4) We engaged youth, community-based organizations, and research partners in prioritizing components and research questions based on our descriptive analyses.
- (5) We conducted factor analyses to confirm which BGYTS components were validated in the data and identify which items were most crucial to each validated component.
- (6) We used structural equation modeling (SEM) to predict youth outcomes in each of our target measures (psychological distress and self-efficacy/hope for the future) based on the BGYTS components and demographic variables collected.
- (7) We engaged youth, community-based organizations, and research partners in making sense of and contextualizing trends seen from the factor analysis and SEM.

The survey report focuses on the BGYTS components and demographics most likely to have a significant and measurable effect on youth outcomes based on results from our SEM models. Visuals throughout the report emphasize the components and demographics that in either model were shown to have a significant, measurable effect. We visualize predicted scores from the factor analysis through circular bar charts. These represent the average expected scores by youth subgroup for BGYTS components that contributed most to our two outcomes. Additionally, we used the factor analysis results to selectively visualize survey items that had the largest direct effect on each BGYTS component. For example, in the “Caring Families and Relationships” component, we focus on the most influential question: “When I have a problem, I have someone

who will be there for me.” We use grouped bar charts to show trends for particular questions by youth subgroups and the outcomes studied.

COMMUNITY AND PARTNER ENGAGEMENT

We held a total of six sessions with community and research partners to define the research and inform survey findings. Two sessions were held with Youth Council members. One focused on identifying the research questions most relevant to L.A. County youth today, and another on making sense of the final observed findings. We also held two sessions each with Bold Vision’s Steering Committee (including one formerly with its predecessor the Community Council) and the SAG. One session focused on receiving further advice on the research questions, and another on additional context for the final observed findings. Sessions were held between October 2024 and April 2025. We used input from these sessions to identify literature that could help contextualize observed trends. Throughout the report, we also provide quotes from Youth Council members to emphasize the experiences of youth in L.A. County and bring life to the findings.

Survey Cleaning

We cleaned the survey data to ensure respondent eligibility and data quality. To determine eligibility, the CHE Group established inclusion criteria for participants who were 15-24 years old, living in L.A. County, and able to understand English or Spanish (the available survey language options).

We also needed to address spam bots – automated tools that complete surveys multiple times to collect response incentives. Because our survey was publicly accessible online, we received numerous invalid responses from these bots. CHE Group used Qualtrics Geofencing, IP address reviews, and ZIP code verification to confirm that responses came from California. Valid responses from eligible participants were retained for analysis, while others were removed. After applying the inclusion and validity criteria, the CHE Group removed 8,288 survey responses, leaving 3,444 responses for analysis.

We also cleaned the data to ensure quality and consistency. CHE Group standardized age and ZIP code responses to numeric values and verified that skip logic functioned correctly. During the final week of data collection, we transitioned from Qualtrics to Question Pro. Despite testing, this migration created skip logic issues where some respondents answered questions they should have skipped. Catalyst California reviewed these cases and corrected responses where participants had been incorrectly directed to questions. For example, if someone didn't select "Asian or Asian American" in the racial identification question but was still directed to specify their Asian ethnic origin, we removed their response to the follow-up question. We corrected 151 response values across all questions with skip logic conditions.

Survey Weighting

Throughout analysis, we used survey weights to correct any imbalances in our survey sample compared to the county population. After the survey sample was cleaned for ineligible or invalid responses, we calculated survey weights using a raking method. The sample was first fitted to the county population based on age then by race, sex, and Service Planning Area (SPA). We used data from the U.S. Census Bureau, American Community Survey, 2018-2022 estimates, subject table S0101 and data profile table DP05 to calculate population benchmarks for each variable. Population rates were compared to sample weights for each variable and then applied iteratively to arrive at the final survey weights. In cases where respondents were missing data, e.g., no race reported, a weight of one was applied for that characteristic. We calculated sample and population rates for each of the following:

Variable	Categories
Age	15-17 18-24
Race	American Indian or Alaska Native, alone non-Latine ¹ Another Race, alone non-Latine Asian, alone non-Latine Black, alone non-Latine Latine, alone or in combination with another race Multiracial, non-Latine Native Hawaiian or Pacific Islander, non-Latine White, alone non-Latine
Sex at Birth	Male Female
Service Planning Area (SPA)	SPA 1 – Antelope Valley SPA 2 – San Fernando Valley SPA 3 – San Gabriel Valley SPA 4 – Metro Los Angeles SPA 5 – West Los Angeles SPA 6 – South Los Angeles SPA 7 – East Los Angeles SPA 8 – South Bay

¹ The U.S. Census Bureau includes indigenous from Mexico, Central America, or South America in this category.

This method does not account for other important characteristics in part due to what data the BGYTS did not collect. For example, the BGYTS did not include questions about socioeconomic

status or parent education level, so survey weights do not account for those characteristics. Additionally, available population data limited our weighting methods. For example, while the BVYTS included detailed data about sexual orientation and gender identity as well as criminal legal system and unhoused status, no reliable population benchmarks exist for L.A. County for these characteristics. Population-based surveys must improve their data collection of vulnerable populations so that reliable benchmarks are available for these groups, like LGBTQIA+, systems-impacted, and unhoused youth.

Survey Demographics

The BVYTS consisted of various demographic questions to measure the identities of the youth surveyed. Respondents were asked 15 detailed demographic questions about their age, ZIP Code, employment, education status, race/ethnicity, sexual orientation, gender, sex at birth, systems involvement, housing status, and immigration status. The survey collected this data to track that our sample was diverse and representative of youth, but also to understand how different backgrounds shape youth experiences.

We aimed to sample as many diverse youth voices as possible. A total of 3,444 valid respondents participated in the survey representing a broad array of L.A. County youth. The table below compares the demographic composition of the BVYTS survey respondents to the L.A. County population ages 15-24. Read our section on survey weighting to understand the ways we accounted for under- or over-representation in our analysis.

DEMOGRAPHIC VARIABLE	SURVEY SAMPLE COUNT	SURVEY SAMPLE PERCENT	L.A. COUNTY POPULATION COUNT	L.A. COUNTY POPULATION PERCENT
Latine	1,878	54.5%	781,040	60%
AIAN	117	3.4%	1,945	0.2%
Asian	398	11.6%	145,935	11.2%
Black	553	16.1%	93,045	7.1%
NHPI	40	1.2%	2,290	0.2%
Multiracial	103	3%	45,820	3.5%
White	194	5.6%	229,893	18%
SWANA	48	1.4%		
Female (sex at birth)	1,967	57.1%	641,164	49.3%
Male (sex at birth)	1,409	40.9%	660,380	50.7%

Cis Man/Boy	1,308	37.9%		
Cis Woman/Girl	1,794	52.1%		
LGBTQIA+	699	20.3%		
Unhoused	423	12.3%		
Immigrant	140	4.1%		
Systems Impacted	459	13.3%		
SPA 1-Antelope Valley	225	6.5%	58,587	4.5%
SPA 2- San Fernando	443	12.9%	271,505	20.9%
SPA 3- San Gabriel	369	10.7%	222,885	17.1%
SPA 4- Metro	476	13.8%	124,978	9.6%
SPA 5- West	141	4.1%	83,072	6.4%
SPA 6- South	1,024	29.7%	166,801	13%
SPA 7- East	348	10.1%	182,044	14%
SPA 8- South Bay	382	11.1%	191,670	14.7%
Age 15-17	1,261	36.6%	367,576	28.2%
Age 18-24	2,183	63.4%	933,968	71.8%

Data Source for LA County Population Estimates: Catalyst California's of the U.S. Census Bureau, American Community Survey, 2018-2022 estimates, Subject Table S0101 and Data Profile Table DP05.

DEFINING UNHOUSED, IMMIGRANT, AND SYSTEMS-IMPACTED YOUTH

Housing instability, temporary immigration status, and a history of criminal legal system involvement can all affect the ability of youth to thrive. Past and current systemic inequities shape the experiences and conditions for these youth. The Bvyts aimed to measure differences in youth needs and experiences across a variety of characteristics, including for youth who have been directly affected by inequities in our housing, immigration, and criminal legal systems. The Bvyts asked youth about their housing, immigration, and systems-impacted status in the following ways.

Housing Status

Question: In the past year, was there ever a time you were homeless or had to stay in any of the following places: a shelter/emergency housing, garage, transitional housing program, motel/hotel, car, park, campground, other public place, trailer/motor home, or temporarily in the home of friends, family, or another person?

Responses: Yes, No, Don't know, Don't wish to answer

Adapted from: Modified from Los Angeles Continuum of Care Homeless Count.

Immigration Status

Question: Do any of the following apply to you: Temporary Protected Status, Asylum Status, Refugee Status, Differed Action for Childhood Arrivals (DACA), Non-Citizen Resident?

Responses: Yes, No, Don't know, Don't wish to answer, Other

Systems-Impacted

Question: At any point, have you: lived in foster care, spent time in juvenile hall or a probation camp, spent time in jail or prison, lived in a group home or residential program, or lived with relatives who were responsible for you legally?

Responses: Yes, No, Don't know, Don't wish to answer

Adapted from: Modified from the National Survey on Family Growth.

The survey additionally asked youth about whether they had ever been detained and/or arrested by law enforcement as well as if they had ever been suspended, subject to an "opportunity transfer", expelled, or subject to other disciplinary actions at school. In a series of models, unhoused, immigration, and systems-impacted status benefited our model fit measures the most out of these other demographics. Therefore, the report focuses on unhoused, immigrant, and systems-impacted youth. Future research can further explore how arrests and school disciplinary actions affect young people thriving in the county.

DEFINING GENDER AND SEXUALITY

For our analyses, we created the category LGBTQIA+ using the survey questions related to gender identity, sex at birth, and sexual orientation. We defined LGBTQIA+ youth as youth who are either non-cisgender or non-heterosexual. We defined cisgender youth as youth whose sex assigned at birth (i.e. Male, Female) matches their gender identity (i.e. Boy or Man, Girl or Woman) and who do not report other gender identities.

Grouping non-cisgender, non-heterosexual respondents together into the LGBTQIA+ category was done to improve statistical power and shed light on this lesser-studied group. Our models also found significant differences between LGBTQIA+ youth and their cisgender, straight counterparts. However, we recognize that creating this category obscures the unique experiences of youth with different sexual orientations and gender identities. For example, a transgender heterosexual respondent and a cisgender queer respondent are both included in the LGBTQIA+ category, though their lived realities may differ significantly. We advocate for further research to unpack the complexity of gender, sex, and sexuality across various youth groups.

Gender

The Bvyts asked about gender identity and sex at birth through the widely recommended two-step question format. The questions read as follows:

Gender Identity

Question: Gender identity is how someone feels about their own gender. There are many ways a person can describe their gender identity and many labels a person can use. Which of the following terms best describes your current gender identity? Check as many boxes as you need.

Response Options: Girl or Woman, Boy or Man, Trans/Transgender, Genderfluid, Two Spirit, Nonbinary or genderqueer, I am not sure or questioning, I do not have a gender/gender identity, Don't wish to answer, Something Else: Please write in.

Adapted from: California Reducing Disparities Project, Statewide Evaluation

Sex Assigned At Birth

Question: What sex were you assigned at birth, on your original birth certificate?

Response Options: Male, Female, Don't wish to answer, Other: Please write in.

Adapted from: California Reducing Disparities Project, Statewide Evaluation

To create the LGBTQIA+ category, we first manually examined all write-in responses and recoded them with existing response options if applicable. For example, respondents who wrote that their gender identity changes over time were recoded as genderfluid.

Then, we labelled respondents who were cisgender boy/man or cisgender girl/woman. If the respondent's sex assigned at birth (i.e. Male, Female) matched their gender identity (i.e. Boy or Man, Girl or Woman) and the respondent did not choose multiple gender identities, the respondent was labelled as cisgender boy/man or cisgender girl/woman.

If the respondent's sex assigned at birth (i.e. Male, Female) did not match their gender identity (i.e. Girl or Woman, Boy or Man) and the respondent did not choose multiple gender identities, we relabeled the respondent as Trans/Transgender and flagged them as LGBTQIA+. Respondents who identified as Trans/Transgender, Genderfluid, Two Spirit, Nonbinary or genderqueer, I do not have a gender/gender identity, or Something else were also labelled as LGBTQIA+. We also created a gender category for gender nonconforming/nonbinary respondents which included Genderfluid, Two Spirit, Nonbinary or genderqueer, I do not have a gender/gender identity, and Something else. Transgender respondents are not included in the gender nonconforming or nonbinary category, but Transgender and gender nonconforming/nonbinary respondents are both included in the LGBTQIA+ category. Respondents who answered "I am not sure or questioning" were not included in analyses for cisgender nor LGBTQIA+ youth. Further analyses should be done on this group to understand how questioning one's gender impacts mental health outcomes.

Sexuality

In the survey, the sexuality question reads as follows:

Sexuality

Question: Sexual orientation is a person's emotional, romantic, and/or sexual attractions to another person. There are many ways a person can describe their sexual orientation and many labels a person can use. Which of these options best describes your sexual orientation? Check as many boxes as you need.

Response Options: Straight or heterosexual, Gay, Lesbian, Bisexual, Queer, Asexual, I am not sure or questioning, I don't know what this question means, Don't wish to answer, Something Else: Please write in.

Adapted from: California Reducing Disparities Project, Statewide Evaluation

To include all non-heterosexual youth in the LGBTQIA+ category, we first manually examined all write-in responses and recoded them with existing response options if applicable. For example, a respondent who wrote in "panromantic asexual" was coded as "Something Else" and "Asexual". Respondents who identified as Gay, Lesbian, Bisexual, Queer, Asexual, or Something else were labelled as LGBTQIA+. Respondents who answered "I am not sure or questioning" or "I don't know what this question means" were not included in analyses for LGBTQIA+ youth. Further analyses should be done on this group to understand how questioning one's sexuality impacts mental health outcomes.

DEFINING RACE AND ETHNICITY

The Bvyts asked three questions about race and ethnic origin. The first we modified from existing U.S. Census questionnaires to be a single question about race and Hispanic origin. It also included categories for SWANA and Indigenous origins from Mexico, Central America, or South America. To help disaggregate data about Asian and Pacific Islander youth, we also included detailed ethnicity questions for these two groups. While our sample size for NHPI youth was too small to meaningfully disaggregate the data, we were able to analyze the data by regional Asian ancestry.

In the survey, the race and ethnicity questions read as follows:

Race

Question: What is your race and ethnic origin? If you are more than one ethnic origin, check a box for each.

Response Options: American Indian and Alaska Native; Black or African American; Indigenous from Mexico, Central America, or South America; Latinx/Latino/a/Hispanic ; Asian or Asian American; Native Hawaiian and Pacific Islander; Southwest Asian and North African; White; Don't Wish to Answer; Other Race

Adapted from: The Office of Management and Budget, Statistical Policy Directive No. 15 on Race and Ethnicity Data Standards, 2024.

Asian Ethnic Origin

Question: What is your Asian/Asian Am. ethnic origin? If you are more than one ethnic origin, check a box for each.

Response Options: Chinese, Asian Indian, Filipino, Korean, Vietnamese, Japanese, Other, Don't Wish to Answer

Adapted from: The Office of Management and Budget, Statistical Policy Directive No. 15 on Race and Ethnicity Data Standards, 2024.

NHPI Ethnic Origin

Question: What is your Native Hawaiian and Pacific Islander ethnic origin? If you are more than one ethnic origin, check a box for each.

Response Options: Samoan, Tongan, Chamarron, Marshallese, Fijian, Māori, PNG, Chuukese, Other, Don't Wish to Answer

Adapted from: The Office of Management and Budget, Statistical Policy Directive No. 15 on Race and Ethnicity Data Standards, 2024.

For all three questions, if a respondent selected “Other”, they were able to provide a write-in response. We manually reviewed all write-in responses and recoded them with existing response options if applicable. We then recoded a respondent’s race and ethnicity two ways: (1) align with American Community Survey (ACS) definitions and support survey weight calculations and (2) capture the preferred racial identities among youth and more accurately assess racial disparities. The latter included analyzing all Black, Indigenous, and People of Color (BIPOC) as one group, distinguishing Southwest Asian or North African (SWANA) from White, and including any youth identifying as NHPI, AIAN, or SWANA in those categories. The table below further details the groups used in the *Brighter Futures* report.

For our analysis, BIPOC is any respondent not recoded as non-Hispanic, White alone. SWANA was kept separate from non-Hispanic, White alone to acknowledge differences in lived experiences as advocated by the community. This category also includes youth identifying as SWANA alone or in combination with Latine or another race. Similarly, data advocates from AIAN and NHPI communities recommend that AIAN and NHPI people are defined as alone or in combination with another race or Latine based on the multiracial histories of these communities. Lastly, because there were relatively few people categorized as non-Hispanic, Other, we did not display them in the report’s charts.

Race/Ethnicity	BVYTS Definition	ACS Alignment
Latine/x/o/a (Latine)	Latine, including Latine alone or in combination with another race	Latine, including Latine alone or in combination with another race
Black	Black alone, non-Latine	Black alone, non-Latine
White	White alone, non-Latine	White and/or Southwest Asian or North African, non-Latine

Asian	Asian alone, non-Latine	Asian alone, non-Latine
Multiracial	Two or more races, non-Latine	Two or more races, non-Latine
Native Hawaiian or Pacific Islander (NHPI)	Native Hawaiian or Pacific Islander, alone or in combination with another race or Latine	Native Hawaiian or Pacific Islander, non-Latine
American Indian or Alaska Native (AIAN)	American Indian or Alaska Native, alone or in combination with another race or Latine	American Indian or Alaska Native and/or Indigenous from Mexico, Central America, or South America; non-Latine
Southwest Asian or North African (SWANA)	Southwest Asian (Middle Eastern) or North African, alone or in combination with another race or Latine	<i>No ACS alignment</i>
Black, Indigenous, and People of Color (BIPOC)	Any combination (one or more) of the above, excluding White alone, non-Latine	<i>No ACS alignment</i>
Other	Other or Don't Wish to Answer or missing response, non-Latine	Other or Don't Wish to Answer or missing response, non-Latine

We included regional Asian subgroups to support disaggregation, as research often groups Asian ethnicities into one category despite significant variation in outcomes across Asian communities. We initially recoded responses for each specific Asian ethnicity (e.g., Chinese, Asian Indian). However, due to sample size limitations, we grouped these into broader regional categories – East Asian, South Asian, and Southeast Asian – to improve statistical power for analysis. While we also identified a Central Asian subgroup, this category included fewer than five youth and was not used in the report. Each regional group was defined by the specific Asian ethnicities reported in our survey, so any ethnicities not listed in the table below were not represented among our respondents.

Regional Asian Subgroup	Definition
East Asian	Chinese, Korean, Japanese, Taiwanese
South Asian	Asian Indian, Bangladeshi, Bengali, Pakistani, Sri Lankan
Southeast Asian	Burmese, Cambodian, Filipino, Indonesian, Khmer, Laotian, Thai, Vietnamese

Survey Nonresponse and Missing Data

Most questions on the BGYTS were forced response, meaning the respondent had to select a response to proceed with the questionnaire. This was done to help reduce survey breakoff and nonresponses. However, when the questionnaire was migrated to QuestionPro for the final month

of data collection, there was a failure in forced response for some questions. We calculated item response rates by survey question and respondent to examine any trends in nonresponse, with and without refusal (Don't wish to answer) and unsure (Unsure/Don't know) responses.

All survey items had response rates over 85% when including refusal and unsure responses as valid responses. Only four items had response rates lower than 95%. These included: a skip logic question about NHPI ethnicity (Q5), a skip logic question about systems involvement (Q24a), a question about education and employment status (Q6), and a question about race and ethnic identity (Q3). We attribute most of these nonresponses to the failure in forced response in QuestionPro.

All survey respondents had response rates of over 85% when including refusal and unsure responses as valid responses. Only 2.1% (n=73) of respondents had response rates between 85-95% and 81% (n=2,791) had a 100% response rate, meaning they answered every question they were asked in the survey. Given the high response rates by item and survey respondent, we included all survey items and valid survey respondents in our analysis.

We then examined patterns in missing data counting refusal and unsure responses as missing responses. For this analysis, we limited variables to those in our structural equation modeling to test for nonresponse bias. Nonresponse rates varied between 0%-11%. Only ten items exceeded a 5% nonresponse rate. These included demographic variables placed at the end of the survey and a limited number of component questions. Our item about immigration status had the highest nonresponse rate (11%) followed by our questions about sexual orientation and gender identity (9%), system-impacted status (7%), unhoused status (7%), and education and employment status (7%). With the exception of education and employment status, these demographic questions were at the end of the survey. Thus, we attribute these higher nonresponse rates to the sensitive nature of demographics questions, along with potential survey fatigue.

Component questions with nonresponse rates over 5% included: a cultural identity question regarding feeling connected to their ancestors (6%); structural inequity questions regarding not having enough affordable housing (6%), money to live off (6%), or career/job opportunities (6%); and finally, having contact with police (7%). We also plotted missing data patterns to evaluate if any data was not missing at random. No patterns were clear other than participants possibly straight-lining refusal or unsure responses in matrix questions. Based on other studies exploring thresholds for missing data and literature on how excluding missing data may bias results even more, we opted to treat the data as missing at random. To test consistency in results, we ran our SEM models with and without the full-information maximum likelihood method. This statistical method estimates values for missing data based on the observed data. In both cases, the models returned similar results, with the key differences being the relative magnitude of each component's and demographic's effect size.

Descriptive Analyses

To analyze the Bvyts data, we first ran numerous descriptive analyses on the survey responses for each survey question, detailed by race and key demographic characteristics. We calculated both the unweighted frequencies, weighted percentages, 90% margins of error, and coefficient of variations (CVs). In the final analysis and report findings, we set a threshold to omit any findings where the CV is greater than 40% or if the unweighted respondent frequencies were less than 5 individuals. We used the R package ‘srvyr’ to apply survey weights and adjust estimates to L.A. County youth characteristics (age, sex, race, and SPA). In our descriptive analyses, we included the youth who responded “Don’t Wish to Answer” or “Don’t Know/Unsure” in question totals but excluded missing or null responses. Percentages shown in the report’s charts may not add to 100% due to rounding and because we did not include the “Don’t Wish to Answer” or “Don’t Know/Unsure” categories in the visuals, though they comprise part of the distributions shown.

For each component-related question in the Bvyts, we ran descriptive analyses by demographics like race, systems-impacted, immigrant status, and gender and sexuality to assess disparities. We also ran disaggregated data by regional Asian ethnicities to demonstrate nuances within this larger racial group. We focused on these demographic characteristics based on the results of our structural equation modeling.

Factor Analysis and Predictions

Using the ‘lavaan’ package in R, we conducted a confirmatory factor analysis (CFA) on all major Bvyts components and subcomponents that included three or more survey items. For instance, the “Microaggressions” subcomponent consisted of four questions, so CFA was used to assess whether these items were statistically loaded onto a single underlying factor. In other words, we wanted to know if all four questions were measuring the same construct of microaggressions. Based on the CFA results, we iteratively refined the components by testing the impact of adding or removing individual items, guided by factor loadings, model fit indices (i.e. CFI, TLI, RMSEA, SRMR), and theoretical relevance.

ITEM REDUCTION

For each component, we removed questions with a factor loading that was less than 0.6.⁶ Then, we ran factor analysis on the reduced components again, which necessitated another item reduction

⁶ Li-tze Hu and Peter M. and Bentler, “Cutoff Criteria for Fit Indexes in Covariance Structure Analysis: Conventional Criteria versus New Alternatives,” *Structural Equation Modeling: A Multidisciplinary Journal* 6, no. 1 (1999): 1–55, <https://doi.org/10.1080/10705519909540118>; Noora Shrestha, “Factor Analysis as a Tool for Survey Analysis,” *American Journal of Applied Mathematics and Statistics* 9, no. 1 (2021): 4–11, <https://doi.org/10.12691/ajams-9-1-2>.

based on the same threshold of 0.6. We compared the model fit measures of the original components and the reduced components, including the comparative fit index (CFI), Tucker-Lewis index (TLI), root mean square error of approximation (RMSEA), and the standardized root mean square residual (SRMR). Model fit measures for all components improved upon item reduction.

FINAL STUDY FACTORS/COMPONENTS

After several rounds of testing, we finalized eight factors to include in structural equation models that were variations from the Bvyts components and subcomponents. They were: Psychological Distress, Self-Efficacy and Hope for the Future, Caring Families and Relationships, Cultural Identity, Microaggressions, Structural Racism, Experiences of Racism and Discrimination, and Vibrant Communities. Each factor had a varying number of items. The table below shows the final validated model factors/components, the related survey question, and the original Bvyts component it came from.

ORIGINAL COMPONENT	VALIDATED MODEL COMPONENT	QUESTIONS
Strong Minds	Psychological Distress	Q9. About how often during the past 30 days did you feel... • worthless • hopeless • so depressed that nothing could cheer you up • restless or fidgety • nervous • feel that everything was an effort
Positive Identity and Hope	Self-Efficacy and Hope for the Future	Q8. How true is each of these about you? • I feel hopeful when I think about my future • I have a lot to look forward to in my life • I believe that I am capable in most things • I am confident I can deal with unexpected events
Caring Families and Relationships	Caring Families and Relationships	Q13. How true are each of these about you? • When I have a problem, I have someone who will be there for me • When something good happens to me, I have people who I like to share the good news with • In my community, there is an adult who really cares about me
Cultural Identity	Cultural Identity	Q15. How true are each of these about you and your cultural identity? • My culture helps me feel good about who I am • My culture gives me strength • My culture is important to me • I feel connected to the spiritual/religious traditions of the culture I was raised in • I feel connected to my ancestors • I feel like I am part of something greater than myself

Racial Equity, Opportunity, and Inclusion	Microaggressions	Q17. During the past 12 months, how often have you dealt with any of the following due to your race? • Being asked to show proof that you were American • Being treated like you are dumb or stupid • Being told hurtful or offensive jokes/comments about your race • Being told that you are a "good example of your race"
Racial Equity, Opportunity, and Inclusion	Structural Racism	Q18. How often do each of these get in the way of you living your best life? • Not enough housing I or my family can afford • Poor quality health services • Not enough money to live off • Poor quality schools • Not enough career/job opportunities • Too much pollution or poisons in the air or water in my neighborhood • Contact with the police
Racial Equity, Opportunity, and Inclusion	Experiences of Racism and Discrimination	Q16. During the past 12 months, how often were you treated unfairly due to your race and being a young person in the following spaces or with the following groups of people? • In a restaurant • In a store • In health clinics or hospitals • At school
Vibrant Communities	Vibrant Communities	Q14. Please tell us more about the resources in your community. The community I live in now has... • Organizations/clubs/programs that I can be a part of • Theater, arts, music events/activities/programs • Religious facilities • Place that I can exercise • Libraries • Businesses that I feel welcomed in • Paid and unpaid work experiences for me • Cultural activities/programs that I can be part of

FACTOR PREDICTIONS

For each survey respondent, we calculated their predicted component scores using the 'lavPredict' function from the 'lavaan' R package. Each respondent received a score for each of the eight final model components (e.g., "Microaggressions") based on their responses and the factor loadings related to that component. Predicted scores were standardized across components, allowing for comparison even when original survey questions varied. This method accounts for the relative importance of each item within the component, unlike calculating a simple average of Likert scale scores. Afterwards, we created circular plots showing the average predicted component scores for

each demographic group. This allowed us to observe which demographic groups were predicted to experience more microaggressions.

LIMITATIONS

As a statistical method, factor analysis groups questions based on response patterns without considering whether these groupings make theoretical sense. We addressed this limitation by using questions from previously validated instruments and working with SAG experts to ensure new items were logically grouped within components before analysis. Additional limitations included: components with fewer than three survey items (e.g., Growth Mindset) could not be analyzed, and respondents who chose 'Don't wish to answer' had to be excluded from the factor analysis.

Structural Equation Modeling

The components validated in the factor analysis were carried into the structural equation models, along with demographic variables to identify which covariates contributed most to our two dependent variables - psychological distress, and self-efficacy and hope for the future. The following is a list of all covariates tested in the structural equation models regardless of if they were retained in the final models:

Imputed Components

- Caring Families and Relationships
- Cultural Identity
- Microaggressions
- Structural Racism
- Vibrant Communities
- Experiences of Racism and Discrimination

Non-imputed subcomponents and singular questions

- Personal safety
- Growth mindset
- Opportunities for community involvement
- Sparks

Demographics

- Race
- LGBTQIA+
- Systems-impacted
- Suspended/expelled/transferred
- Detained/arrested

- Immigrant
- Unhoused
- Connected youth based on employed or enrolled in school
- Age (binary minor/adult)
- Service Planning Area
- Poverty rate by ZIP Code

We tested multiple structural equation models by iteratively adding more covariates and examining the effect of each additional covariate on model fit measures, including R-squared, Akaike Information Criterion (AIC), and Bayesian Information Criterion (BIC). The final two structural equation models included weights, robust standard errors, and full-information maximum likelihood (FIML) for missing data. We reported the completely standardized solution, meaning both the latent and observed variables are standardized to compare coefficient effect sizes. We also ran the structural equation models without FIML and received similar results. To check for multicollinearity, we analyzed the variance inflation factor (VIF) scores for the final models by using the predicted component scores in linear regression models. All VIF scores were less than four, indicating minimal cause for concern.

MODEL 1: PSYCHOLOGICAL DISTRESS

This table below shows the final model for the dependent variable psychological distress. The rows are ordered from greatest to least by absolute effect size. Asterisks indicate significance level: * $p < 0.1$; ** $p < 0.05$; *** $p < 0.01$. Note that the following identities have low sample counts, so their results may be unreliable for policy purposes: AIAN ($n=67$), SWANA ($n=32$), NHPI ($n=27$), and Other Race ($n=3$). For the race variables, the reference group is White respondents. The model's R-squared was 0.321. Additionally, the same model was run on only cisgender respondents to see the effect of cisgender woman/girl on psychological distress, compared to cisgender man/boy. Overall, the results were very similar, and cisgender woman/girl had an effect size of 0.073*** and a standard error of 0.055.

DEPENDENT VARIABLE: PSYCHOLOGICAL DISTRESS	EFFECT SIZE	STANDARD ERROR
Microaggressions	0.216***	0.049
LGBTQIA+	0.195***	0.078
Structural Racism	0.177***	0.042
Caring Families and Relationships	-0.176***	0.043
Sparks	-0.167***	0.067
Personal Safety	-0.079***	0.071

Asian	0.077***	0.103
Cultural Identity	-0.067**	0.038
Systems-impacted	0.058**	0.096
Vibrant Communities	-0.058*	0.040
Black	-0.033	0.109
Immigrant	-0.021	0.141
AIAN	-0.015***	0.167
SWANA	-0.011	0.221
Latine	0.010	0.094
Other Race	-0.007**	0.411
NHPI	0.007	0.285
Multiracial	0.002	0.138

MODEL 2: SELF-EFFICACY AND HOPE FOR THE FUTURE

This table below shows the final model for the dependent variable self-efficacy and hope for the future. The rows are ordered from greatest to least by absolute effect size. Asterisks indicate significance level: * $p < 0.1$; ** $p < 0.05$; *** $p < 0.01$. Note that the following identities have low sample counts, so their results may be unreliable for policy purposes: AIAN ($n=67$), SWANA ($n=32$), NHPI ($n=27$), and Other Race ($n=3$). The model's R-squared was 0.314. In addition, the same model was run on only cisgender respondents to see the effect of cisgender woman/girl on self-efficacy and hope for the future, compared to cisgender man/boy. Overall, the results were very similar, and cisgender woman/girl had an effect size of 0.072*** and a standard error of 0.060.

DEPENDENT VARIABLE: SELF-EFFICACY AND HOPE FOR THE FUTURE	EFFECT SIZE	STANDARD ERROR
Caring Families and Relationships	0.289***	0.043
Sparks	0.231***	0.068
Cultural Identity	0.231***	0.040
Asian	-0.154***	0.108

LGBTQIA+	-0.139***	0.072
Unhoused	0.072**	0.104
Opportunities for Community Involvement	0.069***	0.142
Latine	-0.062*	0.091
Personal Safety	0.048**	0.069
Multiracial	-0.048*	0.152
Percent of population living under 200% FPL in ZIP Code	0.030	0.002
SWANA	-0.027	0.233
Black	0.024	0.099
Other Race	0.017	0.615
Has been suspended, subjected to opportunity transfer, expelled, or had parents called for school incident	-0.008	0.081
AIAN	0.007	0.172
Systems-impacted	-0.005	0.099
NHPI	0.001	0.186

LIMITATIONS

SEMs are sensitive to small sample sizes, which can lead to unstable coefficient estimates. In our models, some groups have considerably small sample sizes, such as AIAN, NHPI, and SWANA youth. Estimates for smaller sample-sized groups should not be used without referring to additional research or conducting further analyses. To theoretically ground our models, the BvyTS components were constructed based on thorough literature reviews of youth thriving and expert guidance from Bold Vision's Community Council and SAG. That being said, the variables used in the SEMs are restricted by the survey questions asked and do not account for other unknown variables that may be relevant but were not collected or not observable. In addition, we recognize that the distinction between a dependent or independent variable does not exactly align with Bold Vision's definition of youth thriving as a holistic framework. For instance, having a spark reduces psychological distress, but having less psychological distress can help youth identify their sparks. However, identifying causal effects requires an experimental research design beyond the scope of the BvyTS.

Crosstabs and Subgroup Analysis

Based on our factor analysis, structural equation modeling and feedback from the Youth Council, we identified the most crucial survey components, questions, and demographics to detail in the report. Variables were selected that had a statistically greater impact in the SEMs and/or were most relevant to the issues youth are facing today. Crosstab functions were created in RStudio to run calculations on two or three variables. Unweighted counts, weighted rates, and CVs were also calculated in these crosstabs to evaluate data stability before presenting trends in the report. Again, we do not include estimates for subgroups with fewer than five respondents or CVs higher than 40%.

Cross-tabulations were run for survey questions in components that had a proven significant effect on youth outcomes. This was done to help synthesize and visualize the effect of certain components on youth outcomes in more understandable ways other than SEM. Questions were often selected based on the strength of their factor loadings in the CFA. Demographics highlighted in the report are often selected based on results from the SEMs or input from the Youth Council. For example, we include specific callouts and sometimes data disaggregation for LGBTQIA+, Asian, immigrant, Black, and systems-impacted youth because these demographics were significant in the SEMs or mentioned as important to youth today. These callouts are meant to be examples of nuances within these groups but should not be considered an in-depth analysis of their conditions or needs. We encourage additional research to dive into trends and nuances within these groups to further understand their unique needs and potential policy interventions to improve their level of thriving.